

NAVLE High-Yield & Commonly-Missed Topics

One-week focused review guide

Important honesty note: The NAVLE is a secure, copyrighted exam, and the ICVA (formerly NBVME) does not release real exam questions, so no legitimate list of “actual past questions” exists. What follows instead is the official ICVA exam blueprint (published, public data) plus the content areas that veterinary students and major review programs (VetPrep, Zuku, Vet Candy, ICVA self-assessments) most consistently flag as high-yield or as common sources of missed points. Use it to prioritize, not as leaked content.

1. Official Exam Blueprint (ICVA)

The exam is 360 multiple-choice questions. ICVA sets targets from its Practice Analysis survey of working veterinarians. Study time should roughly track these weights.

Species distribution

Species	Target %
Canine	25.6%
Feline	24.3%
Equine	14.7%
Bovine	13.3%
Porcine	5%
Other small mammals	3.3%
Ovine/Caprine	3.3%
Pet bird	2.3%
Poultry	2%
Camelid/Cervidae	1.7%
Reptiles	1.5%
Aquatics	1%
Non species-specific	2%

Takeaway: dogs + cats ≈ 50% of the exam. Equine + bovine + small ruminant + porcine together ≈ 36%. Exotics/aquatics are individually small but add up — know the 2–3 biggest diagnoses per group rather than skipping them entirely.

Competency domain distribution

Domain	Target %
Data Gathering & Interpretation	35%
Health Maintenance & Problem Management	35%
Animal Welfare / Preventive Medicine	6–15%
Client Communication	5%
Environmental Health & Safety	5%
Practice Management	4%
Veterinary Public Health	4%
Communication with Vet Professionals	3%
Professional Development	3%

Clinical practice (history, exam findings, diagnostics, case management) is ~70% of the exam. This is why case-based/vignette practice questions matter more than flashcard memorization alone.

2. High-Yield “Bread and Butter” Conditions by Species

These are the common, frequently-tested presentations — the diseases review programs describe as showing up far more than rare “zebras.” Master these cold before chasing obscure differentials.

Canine

- diabetes mellitus & DKA, hypothyroidism, hyperadrenocorticism (Cushing's) vs. Addison's
- parvovirus, distemper, kennel cough complex, leptospirosis
- IMHA, ITP, von Willebrand disease
- GDV, IBD, pancreatitis, hepatic disease/portosystemic shunt
- degenerative joint disease, IVDD, cranial cruciate rupture, hip dysplasia
- dilated cardiomyopathy, mitral valve disease, heartworm disease
- dermatology: atopic dermatitis, otitis externa, demodicosis vs. sarcoptic mange

Feline

- hyperthyroidism, diabetes mellitus, CKD (very high yield — know staging/IRIS)
- FLUTD/urethral obstruction (emergency recognition), FIP, FeLV/FIV
- hypertrophic cardiomyopathy, asthma/bronchitis
- hepatic lipidosis, triaditis, IBD

Equine

- colic classification (large vs. small intestine, strangulating vs. non-strangulating) — heavily tested clinical reasoning
- laminitis, colitis (Salmonella, Potomac horse fever), equine metabolic syndrome/PPID
- respiratory: strangles, equine influenza, recurrent airway obstruction
- lameness/orthopedic exam localization, EPM, botulism, tetanus
- reproductive: dystocia, neonatal (failure of passive transfer, sepsis)

Bovine

- LDA/RDA, ketosis, hypocalcemia (milk fever), retained placenta, metritis
- BVDV, IBR, bovine respiratory disease complex (shipping fever)
- Johne's disease, coccidiosis, calf scours (rotavirus/coronavirus/ E. coli/ crypto)
- mastitis (types & SCC interpretation), herd health / reproductive programs, pregnancy diagnosis timing

Small ruminants & camelids

- caseous lymphadenitis, CAE/OPP, parasitism (Haemonchus, FAMACHA), enterotoxemia (Clostridium perfringens)
- pregnancy toxemia, polioencephalomalacia, urolithiasis in males

Porcine

- PRRS, swine influenza, African swine fever (foreign animal disease awareness), erysipelas
- herd biosecurity, production medicine, neonatal piglet diarrhea

Poultry / pet birds

- Marek's disease, avian influenza (reportable disease protocols), infectious bronchitis
- psittacine: PBFD, chlamydiosis (zoonotic — know reporting duty)

Exotics / reptiles / small mammals

- metabolic bone disease (reptiles), GI stasis (rabbits/guinea pigs), dental disease (rodents/rabbits)

- hindgut fermenter nutrition principles

3. Commonly Missed / Underperformed Areas

These aren't necessarily rare topics — they're categories where prepared students still lose points because they're easy to under-study relative to clinical medicine.

Calculations

- fluid rates, CRIs, drug dose conversions, anion gap / acid-base math — practice these under time pressure, not just conceptually

Toxicology

- ethylene glycol, chocolate/xylitol, NSAID/rodenticide, lead, ivermectin toxicity in herding-breed dogs, plant toxicities (large animal)

Public health & regulatory

- reportable/foreign animal diseases (who to notify, federal vs. state authority), zoonotic disease transmission and prevention, rabies protocols post-exposure
- food safety/withdrawal times for food animals, meat/milk residue avoidance

Practice management & legal

- controlled substance (DEA) recordkeeping, informed consent, VCPR requirements, telemedicine limitations

Animal welfare & ethics

- euthanasia method appropriateness by species, humane transport/handling, recognizing and reporting animal cruelty

Client communication

- breaking bad news, declining euthanasia requests, non-compliant clients — these are scored like clinical questions, not “freebies”

4. One-Week Study Strategy

- Days 1–2: Take a full-length practice exam (ICVA self-assessment or VetPrep/Zuku) to find your weakest domains/species before spending more time.
- Days 3–5: Triage by blueprint weight — canine/feline first, then equine/bovine, then the non-clinical categories above (welfare, public health, calculations) since they're often neglected.
- Day 6: Timed mixed-question blocks (60–90 min) simulating exam pacing; review every miss for the underlying concept, not just the fact.
- Day 7 (day before): Light review only — skim your weak-area notes, sleep, no new material.

Sources consulted: ICVA/NBVME published NAVLE blueprint and species/diagnosis guide (icva.net); VetPrep blog “What's Covered on the NAVLE”; Zuku Review triage/high-yield guidance; Vet Candy “Blueprint Strategy” article (2026). Percentages reflect ICVA's 2017 Practice Analysis, the most recent published at time of writing — confirm nothing has been updated via icva.net before your exam.